

The Flavors of South America

Few continents have been blessed with as varied a culinary heritage as South America, and this heritage is gaining wider international acclaim as more travelers start exploring the many different aspects of these nations. Rich stews and soups dominate the cooler mountain regions, while the long coastlines offer up fresh fish cured and cooked in unusual ways. Simply delicious beef is on the menu almost everywhere, but nowhere better than from the pampas of Argentina.

The indigenous peoples of South America, the conquering Spaniards and Portuguese, and a large influx of African slaves have all contributed their distinct cooking traditions and ingredients to the culinary mix in the continent. And as if these weren't enough, Chinese, Japanese, Jewish, Indian, Lebanese, German, French, Italian, and British gastronomical influences have followed in their wake, making South America a true foodie melting pot.

Many of the most popular foods enjoyed worldwide – potatoes, chili and sweet peppers, peanuts, corn, and the one with the

highest “yummy factor” of all: chocolate – hail from South America.

In an unofficial exchange, Europeans introduced chicken, pork, beef (along with dairy products), wheat, sugar, citrus trees, onions, and garlic, as

well as certain herbs and spices such as oregano, parsley, and cloves, to South America, and also passed on their winemaking techniques, all of which changed the food culture forever.

Today's cuisine has come a long way from its humble beginnings of often corn-based dishes, and the gastronomical centers of Lima, Buenos Aires, and Rio de Janeiro now boast world-class restaurants. Food festivals, such as Lima's Mistura

and Medellín's Otro Sabor, also attract visitors from near and far. What's influenced South American cuisine more than any other feature is also what has inspired many a traveler – its wonderful variety of landscapes: desolate high plateaus, deeply cut ravines, snow-capped *cordilleras* (mountain ranges), endless rolling pasturelands, and the sheer immensity of the Amazon basin.

Coast-to-Coast Cuisines

In South America, food is often regional, rather than national, in character: warming stews and soups in the Andean region, good fish and seafood along the lengthy coastlines and mighty rivers, and superb beef in the cattle and farming areas. Peru's famous *ceviche* (lime-cured seafood with salt and perhaps a sprinkling of chili pepper) is popular along many parts of the Pacific and Caribbean coasts. In Colombia and Venezuela, as well as northern

The gastronomical centers of Lima, Buenos Aires, and Rio de Janeiro now boast world-class restaurants.

Right One of the many vibrant street markets in Cusco, Peru
Below Harvesting coffee at a plantation near Ciudad Bolívar, Colombia

